Cresta / Improving — Connect on AI

June 9, 2026 | 4:00–4:30 PM CT | Microsoft Teams | Jessica Groshek

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1. Background / History

Jessica Groshek is Vice President of ESG and External Affairs at Cresta Fund Management, a role she has held since January 2024 when she was promoted — the first person to hold that title at the firm. She joined Cresta in 2022 in a senior ESG capacity.

Before Cresta, she was Director of Sustainability and Investor Relations at Vistra Corp, one of the largest power generators in the US. At Vistra she built the company's first annual sustainability report, developed its Green Finance Framework, managed climate risk and opportunity analysis, and led ESG investor engagement. Prior to Vistra she worked at Luminant. She holds a degree from Southern Methodist University (Dallas).

Her functional footprint spans sustainability strategy, ESG integration, investor communications, media relations, and external stakeholder engagement. She sits at the intersection of institutional communications and operational ESG — not a pure investor relations role and not purely operational; she bridges both.

Prior relationship with David / Improving: No documented prior engagement was found. This appears to be a first-touch or early-stage relationship.

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2. Company Overview

Cresta Fund Management is a Dallas-based private equity firm focused on middle-market infrastructure investing, founded in 2016. The firm manages approximately $1.6 billion in AUM across funds targeting logistics, transportation, energy midstream, industrial, and agricultural sectors in the US. Typical check sizes run $50M to $250M.

The firm's strategic identity has evolved toward sustainable infrastructure. Cresta's thesis is that the energy transition will be anchored by economically viable investments that decarbonize the highest-emitting industrial sectors. Portfolio companies include:

- **Lapis Energy** — carbon capture and storage platform
- **Braya Renewable Fuels** — renewable diesel (refinery conversion)
- **Sentinel Midstream** — energy transportation and storage

Cresta operates a formal Responsible Investment Policy and treats ESG integration as a firm-level differentiator, not just a reporting checkbox. Jessica's role formalizes that commitment both internally (portfolio integration) and externally (LP communications, media, stakeholder engagement).

The firm is small and lean — approximately 10 investment professionals, headquartered at 2950 N. Harwood Street, Dallas, TX. Leadership includes CEO Frank Almaraz and co-founders Drew Armstrong, Chris Rozzell, and David Miller.

AI/tech signal: No public indication of a formal AI or digital transformation initiative was found. Jessica's outreach under a "Connect on AI" label likely reflects either (a) a firm-level interest in how AI applies to their portfolio operations or ESG workflows, or (b) personal/professional curiosity she's driving. Treat this as exploratory until confirmed.

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3. Improving's Position

This is a Sales-category meeting. The objective is to open the conversation, understand Jessica's specific AI interest or need, and identify whether there is a fit with Improving's capabilities — either at the Cresta firm level or across their portfolio companies.

What Improving brings:

Improving is a technology consulting firm with deep AI delivery capability. The differentiator is not advisory slides but production-grade implementation, shaped by the Intelligence Operating System (IOS) — an 8-stage AI adoption framework that replaces expensive experimentation with a structured path from Zero AI to full Agentic Operations.

Relevant capability clusters for a firm like Cresta:

- **AI strategy and readiness assessments** — for Cresta itself or for portfolio companies at different maturity levels
- **ESG and sustainability data workflows** — AI-assisted data collection, reporting automation, and audit preparation; directly relevant to Jessica's role managing ESG integration across portfolio companies
- **Agentic AI and workflow automation** — operational efficiency plays that resonate in middle-market PE-backed companies where headcount is constrained
- **AI adoption and enablement** — Improving's practitioners build real skills into client teams, which matters for a lean firm like Cresta
- **Microsoft 365 and Azure AI integration** — Improving's stack aligns with what most PE firms and their portfolio companies run
- **Anthropic / Claude-based production deployments** — Improving has certified capability with Claude models in production environments where reliability is non-negotiable

The average Improving engagement runs 7.5 years. That long-horizon partnership model is a credibility signal worth surfacing with a firm that runs concentrated, multi-year portfolio positions.

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4. Proposed Agenda

30-minute call, Microsoft Teams

Time	Topic
0:00–0:05	Introductions, confirm purpose and context for the call
0:05–0:12	Jessica's framing: what prompted the AI connect, what she's exploring or trying to solve

Time	Topic
0:12–0:20	Improving's overview: IOS framework, relevant capability areas, examples of similar engagements
0:20–0:27	Discussion: fit assessment — is AI interest at the firm level, portfolio level, or both?
0:27–0:30	Wrap: identify logical next step (deeper dive, specific capability demo, or broader intro)

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5. Talking Points

Open with curiosity, not a pitch. Jessica requested the connect and her title is ESG/External Affairs, not CTO or IT. The AI interest could be coming from several directions — lead with a question, not a deck.

Probe questions worth having ready:

- "What's prompting the AI interest from your seat — is this a firm-level operational question, something you're seeing across portfolio companies, or both?"
- "Are your portfolio companies at the same ESG maturity level, or is there wide variance you're trying to manage?"
- "What does your current ESG data and reporting workflow look like — any manual bottlenecks you're working around?"
- "Have you had any previous AI pilots or vendor conversations, or is this a standing-start exploration?"

Improving's hook for this audience. The ESG angle is the strongest entry point. Cresta's competitive differentiation is built on ESG credibility with LPs. If AI can make Jessica's ESG integration work faster, more consistent, and more auditable across portfolio companies, that directly supports the firm's brand promise. Lead with operational value in ESG workflows before pivoting to broader AI strategy.

The portfolio angle. Cresta manages companies in carbon capture, renewable fuels, and midstream energy. These are operationally complex businesses where AI-assisted process optimization, safety monitoring, and reporting have real ROI. If Jessica is thinking about portfolio company support, that's a different (and potentially larger) engagement surface than what Cresta itself would need.

Size and lean team. With roughly 10 investment professionals, Cresta is not going to stand up an internal AI center of excellence. Frame Improving as the external capability that makes a lean, high-conviction team punch above its weight — not a vendor relationship, a partnership.

Don't over-pitch the IOS framework by name. The 8-stage model is useful context internally; surface it as "a structured path we use to remove guesswork" rather than leading with the acronym.

Know the distinction. There is a separate company called Cresta (AI contact center platform, Palo Alto-based, $270M raised). If any confusion arises on the call, clarify quickly. Cresta Fund Management is the PE firm; the AI company Cresta is unrelated.